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The opening day of Make it in the Emirates 2026 in Abu Dhabi saw a large turnout yesterday, with the event featuring 1,245 exhibitors.

Virendra Saklani/Gulf News

UAE shifts focus to domestic investment

Ministers outline strategy linking energy, industry and supply chain resilience

ABU DHABI

BY NIVETHA DAYANAND
Assistant Business Editor

The UAE is preparing to scale up domestic investment while reshaping its industrial and energy strategy, ministers said at the Make it in the Emirates summit, as the country responds to recent supply chain and market disruptions.

Minister of Foreign Trade Thani Bin Ahmed Al Zeyoudi said the next phase will focus more on local deployment of capital. "Moving forward, for sure, we're going to continue our international investments, but also we're going to have huge investments internally," he said, adding that infrastructure and strategic projects will be prioritised.

Energy Minister Suhail Mo-

hamed Al Mazrouei linked the UAE's exit from Opec to industrial flexibility, saying, "We will have a sense of freedom to produce what we require without joining any group," while continuing to act as a responsible supplier.

Industry Minister Sultan Ahmed Al Jaber said the move forms part of a broader economic shift. "It is a carefully considered strategic decision that reflects our confidence in our capabilities," he said, positioning the policy within a push to strengthen domestic industry and resilience.

The comments underscore a coordinated strategy to expand local capacity, secure supply chains and align energy production with industrial growth, as the UAE adapts to a more volatile global environment.

SEE ALSO P8-9

UAE SLAMS BRUTAL IRANIAN AGGRESSION

Drone hits tanker, missiles intercepted, Fujairah fire injures 3

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

The UAE yesterday condemned the brutal Iranian aggression after Tehran targeted an oil tanker operated by Abu Dhabi National Oil Company (Adnoc) in the Strait of Hormuz and launched missiles and drones towards the country, with air defences intercepting three of four cruise missiles.

Authorities in Fujairah confirmed a blaze at the Fujairah Oil Industry Zone (FOIZ), resulting from a drone attack coming from Iran that injured three Indians, saying civil defence teams responded immediately and were working to contain the fire.

The UAE said the attacks represent a serious escalation, an unacceptable act of aggression, and a direct threat to the coun-

try's security, stability and territorial integrity, in violation of international law and the Charter of the United Nations.

The Ministry of Defence said four cruise missiles were detected heading towards the UAE from Iran. Three were successfully intercepted over territorial waters, while the fourth fell harmlessly into the sea.

State news agency WAM also cited the ministry as saying its forces were working to repel missile and drone attacks coming from Iran.

Successful interceptions

The ministry added that sounds heard across several areas were linked to the successful interceptions of the aerial threats.

The developments came as the UAE strongly condemned a separate Iranian drone attack targeting a national oil tanker

The attacks highlight an ongoing threat posed by Iran to regional security and stability and such risks cannot be overlooked.

operated by Adnoc as it transited the Strait of Hormuz.

In its statement, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs described the tanker strike as a flagrant violation of international law and stressed that targeting commercial shipping or using the strait as a tool of coercion poses a direct threat to regional stability, global energy security and international trade.

The UAE called on Iran to halt such attacks immediately and ensure the full, unconditional reopening of the vital waterway.

Dr Anwar Gargash, Diplomati-

Advisor to the President, echoed the condemnation, describing the targeting of the tanker as brutal Iranian aggression and warning that such actions cannot be overlooked. He reaffirmed the UAE's position on safeguarding freedom of navigation in the strategic maritime corridor.

'Project Freedom'

Meanwhile, the US Central Command said American guided-missile destroyers had entered the Arabian Gulf as part of a mission to support "Project Freedom," a naval initiative announced by Donald Trump to help move stranded ships.

CENTCOM said US forces were "actively assisting" efforts to restore commercial transit and confirmed that two US-flagged merchant vessels had already passed safely through the strait.

However, the US has stopped short of full naval escorts. Ac-

cording to *The Wall Street Journal*, officials have deliberately framed the mission as "guiding" rather than escorting ships, signalling a more limited posture even as tensions escalate.

Iran has warned that any foreign naval presence in the strait could trigger further escalation. Major General Ali Abdollahi said security in the waterway should be handled by regional states, cautioning against outside intervention.

The twin incidents — the strike on Fujairah and the tanker attack in Hormuz — underscore rising tensions across the Gulf, where military activity and threats to shipping have intensified in recent weeks.

Oil prices climbed, with the benchmark international contract Brent crude for July delivery jumping more than five per cent.

SEE ALSO P5, 6, 12

A day of shocks as India's political map is redrawn

Bengal breakthrough, TN upset and Kerala swing define results

DUBAI

BY ALEX ABRAHAM
Senior Associate Editor

It was a day of shocks in India as results from four states and one Union Territory redrew the political map, delivering both decisive wins and dramatic upsets.

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) secured a historic breakthrough in West Bengal, winning 194 and leading in 13 of 294 seats and on the way to form its first government in the state. The party also re-

tained Assam for a third consecutive term and maintained an edge in Puducherry.

Biggest surprise

The biggest surprise came from Tamil Nadu, where actor C. Joseph Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam surged in its debut election, disrupting decades of Dravidian dominance.

In Kerala, the Congress-led United Democratic Front returned to power after 10 years, defeating the Left in a clear anti-incumbency verdict.

Together, the results point to a fragmented but decisive mandate, shaped by strong regional currents rather than a single national trend.

SEE ALSO P13

Dubai Airports ramps up flights

Regional access improves, easing pressure on DXB operations

DUBAI

BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

Dubai International Airport is ramping up operations after the UAE lifted precautionary airspace restrictions, pointing to a gradual recovery in regional aviation.

Dubai Airports said it will increase daily flight movements and allow airlines to rebuild schedules, while noting that capacity depends on the availability of regional airspace outside UAE. Flights have continued via safe

corridors since March 1, supported by coordination across the "oneDXB" network, including Emirates and flydubai. This helped sustain passenger and cargo flows during the disruption and positions the hub for a faster scale-up as conditions stabilise.

6 million passengers

Between February 28 and April 30, the airport handled six million passengers, more than 32,000 flights, and 213,000 tonnes of cargo despite the crisis linked to the US-Israel-Iran conflict.

Chief Executive Paul Griffiths described the period as "unprecedented" for a global hub and underscored DXB's role in international transit. "Maintaining smooth operations here is critical to keep global journeys moving," he said, noting that 22.4 million

annual transfer passengers pass through the airport.

He said coordinated action across the aviation system supported continuity. "Our collective response has sharpened our ability to adapt at pace," he noted.

Griffiths outlined the scale of the threat, saying, "We actually had 114 different missile alerts during the entire conflict period... about three a day." He added that intelligence support was "fantastic" and that teams were able to move people "very quickly to positions of safety."

The disruption weighed on traffic. Passenger numbers fell 20.6 per cent year-on-year in the first quarter of 2026, with March traffic down 65.7 per cent, reflecting the impact of regional airspace constraints.

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WORLD

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Three dead, many ill in suspected outbreak | P11

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